Unit 7: What You Do is What You Are

Complete exercise solutions — all textbook questions answered (full book, 14 units)

Reading and Critical Thinking — Exercise A (Answers)

Q1. Why does the author describe the way society defines people by their jobs as peculiar?

• The author finds it peculiar because society defines and judges everybody in terms of the work they do, especially work performed for pay. "It is as if by defining how a person earns his or her rent money, we validate or reject that person's existence."

• It is peculiar because a person's worth as a human being should not depend on a job title. The author says, "People aren't cast in bronze because of the jobs they hold or once held."

• It is also peculiar that we assign unemployed people to "limbo" and define them only by their past job history, as if they are nothing now.

Q2. Provide two examples the author uses to show how individuals are judged based on their employment status or past jobs.

• Example 1: "Larry is a laid-off auto worker; Tony is a retired teacher; Sally is a former showgirl and blackjack dealer from Vegas." The author says we assign such people to limbo and define them in terms of their past job history.

• Example 2: "A retired teacher, for example, may spend a lot of volunteer time working with handicapped children or raising money for the Loyal Order of Hibernating Hibiscus. That apparently auto worker may pump gas at his cousin's gas station or sell encyclopaedia on weekends. But who's Larry? Until and unless he begins to work steadily again, he's a laid-off auto worker."

• A third example: women who have kept a house and reared six children refer to themselves as "just a housewife."

Q3. What does the phrase "cast in bronze" symbolise in the context of the text?

"Cast in bronze" means permanently fixed or frozen in one form, like a statue. The author says people aren't cast in bronze because of their jobs — a person is not permanently fixed by a job title. People change, grow, and do many things beyond their employment. The phrase symbolises the false idea that a job permanently defines a person.

Q4. The author mentions certain professions like "just a housewife" or "just a janitor." What is the critique behind these labels, and what point is the author trying to make?

• The word "just" discounts a person completely. To be "just" anything is the worst — it means not being recognised by society as having much value at all.

• The "just" category contains present non-earners, people with no valued job history, and people whose jobs are on the low end of pay and prestige. A person can be "just" a cab driver or "just" a janitor, but no one is ever "just" a vice-president.

• The author's point is that the label "just" reveals an unfair hierarchy of respect. Society values people by pay and prestige, not by their real contribution.

Q5. In what way does the author suggest that children should be taught to understand respect and job roles in society?

• The author says it is no use arguing whether the system is correct or proper — rationally it is silly — but "that's our system, however, and we should not only keep it in mind, we should teach our children how it works."

• Children should know that the cattle breeder is much more respected than the hired hand, and the doctor gets more respect and privilege than the nurse — quite apart from earnings potential.

• The point is that children should understand how society actually distributes respect, so they are not surprised by it, even though the system is irrational.

Q6. What is McWhirter's tone? Illustrate it with a few words and phrases that establish the tone.

• McWhirter's tone is reflective, ironic, and mildly critical. He is not angry but thoughtful, using irony to expose the absurdity of the system.

• Phrases that establish the tone: "This seems peculiar to me," "It is no use arguing whether any of this is correct or proper. Rationally it is silly," "I have no answers to any of this," and the humorous example of the "Loyal Order of Hibernating Hibiscus."

• The tone is also conversational and questioning — the author invites the reader to think rather than preaching.

Q7. Why does the author state that no one is ever described as "just" a vice-president? What does this reveal about how society values certain jobs?

• No one is ever "just" a vice-president because the word "just" is used only for low-paying, low-prestige jobs. High-status jobs carry respect automatically, so they never need to be discounted.

• This reveals that society values jobs by pay and prestige, not by the person's worth. The hierarchy is so strong that even the language reflects it — "just" is reserved for the devalued.

Q8. Do you agree with the writer's view that society unfairly defines people by their jobs or employment status? Why or why not?

• Yes, I agree. The writer shows that a retired teacher doing volunteer work or a woman who has reared six children is still labelled "just" something, which is unfair.

• A person's worth should be judged by character, contribution, and kindness, not by job title or pay. The writer's examples — the laid-off auto worker, the housewife, the janitor — prove that society discounts real human value.

• However, one might add that jobs do matter for skills and responsibility; the unfairness lies in using the job as the whole definition of the person.

Exercise B — Excerpt Analysis (Answers)

• **Effect of "assign that person to limbo":** "Limbo" is a place of waiting and uncertainty. The phrase shows that society puts unemployed people in a state of suspension — neither valued nor recognised — as if their existence is on hold.

• **Attitude towards the unemployed:** The phrase reflects a dismissive attitude. Society treats the unemployed as if they do not count until they earn money again.

Exercise C — Fact or Opinion (Answers)

• i. "People aren't cast in bronze because of the jobs they hold or once held." — **Opinion** (a general belief about human identity).

• ii. "A retired teacher, for example, may spend a lot of volunteer time working with handicapped children..." — **Fact** (a specific, verifiable example).

• iii. "To be 'just' anything is the worst." — **Opinion** (a value judgement).

• iv. "We still hear it all the time. Sometimes women who have kept a house and reared six children refer to themselves as 'just' a housewife." — **Fact** (an observable social practice).

Exercise D — Précis (Model, 80–100 words)

Society unfairly defines people by their jobs, especially paid work. We validate or reject a person's existence through job titles, and we assign the unemployed to "limbo," defining them by past jobs. The word "just" — as in "just a housewife" or "just a janitor" — discounts people completely, though no one is ever "just" a vice-president. Although we claim to be a classless society, we separate the valued from the valueless by job prestige. The author finds this system peculiar and irrational, yet believes children should be taught how it works.

Vocabulary Exercises (Answers)

• **1. "validate" —** Confirm as worthy. Reasoning: "by defining how a person earns his rent money, we validate or reject that person's existence" — society confirms or denies a person's worth through their job.

• **2. "cast in bronze" —** To be honoured forever / permanently fixed. Reasoning: "People aren't cast in bronze because of the jobs they hold" — a job does not permanently fix a person's identity.

• **3. "uncatalogued system" —** A random or informal set of social rules. Reasoning: the system of awarding respect by jobs is not written down or organised; it is an unspoken social habit.

Grammar — Gerunds, Infinitives, and Participles (Answers)

• **Identify:** 1. "Judging people by their jobs is common in our society." — Judging = **Gerund** (subject). 2. "Some individuals are reduced to being 'just' something." — being = **Gerund phrase**. 3. "To assign value based on job titles is deeply flawed." — To assign = **Infinitive** (subject). 4. "The author criticised the unthinking use of the word 'just'." — unthinking = **Present Participle** (adjective). 5. "To grow up wanting respect should not depend on one's profession." — To grow up = **Infinitive phrase**. 6. "Discounted by society, many people struggle with identity." — Discounted = **Past Participle**.

• **Transform and use:** judge — judging (Gerund: Judging others is unfair), to judge (Infinitive: To judge people by jobs is wrong), judging (Participle: Judging by appearances, he misjudged her). define — defining, to define, defined. respect — respecting, to respect, respected.

• **Fill in the blanks:** 1. Society often **assigns** value based on job titles. 2. The idea of ranking people as "less than" is deeply troubling. 3. The author urges readers **to question** their own assumptions. 4. **Limited** by job labels, many feel their full identity is lost. 5. She **continued finding** value beyond her employment history.

Writing Tasks — Model Answers

A. Analytical Essay: All Professions Deserve Equal Respect

• **Introduction:** Society judges people by their jobs, but does a janitor deserve less respect than a doctor? This essay argues that all professions, regardless of pay or status, deserve equal respect.

• **Body:** McWhirter shows that the word "just" discounts people unfairly — "just a housewife," "just a janitor" — while no one is ever "just a vice-president." A housewife who rears six children performs unpaid labour of great value. A janitor keeps hospitals and schools clean, protecting public health. Respect should be based on the usefulness and dignity of work, not on pay scales. Even the cattle breeder and the hired hand, the doctor and the nurse, all contribute to society.

• **Conclusion:** Jobs do not define a person's worth. Every profession deserves equal respect because every worker contributes to the community. Society should learn to value the person, not the job title.

B. Translation into English (Model)

There is a whole category of other people who are "just" something. To be "just" anything is the worst. It is not to be recognised by society as having much value at all, not now and probably not in the past either. To be "just" anything is to be totally discounted, at least for the present. There are lots of people who are "just" something. "Just" a housewife immediately and painfully comes to mind. We still hear it all the time. Sometimes women who have kept a house and reared six children refer to themselves as "just" a housewife. "Just" a bum, "just" a kid, "just" a drunk, bag lady, old man, student, punk are some others. You can probably add to the list. The "just" category contains present non-earners, people who have no past job history highly valued by society, and people whose present jobs are on the low end of pay and prestige scales. A person can be "just" a cab driver, for example, or "just" a janitor. No one is ever "just" a vice-president, however.

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